

Phishing Detection & Awareness Report

Analysis of Real-World Phishing Emails

Prepared by: Kenny Ntsako Kosa
Cyber Security Intern - Future Interns
Date: June 26, 2026

Red Flags for Email 1

Red Flag	Explanation (Write this in your report)
1. Generic Greeting	"Dear User" – A real bank always uses your full name.
2. Fake Sender Domain	The link secure-account-verify[.]com is NOT a real bank website.
3. Suspicious Link	The link text says "Verify Now" but hides the real fake destination.
4. Urgency & Fear	"24 hours" and "permanent account lock" – they use fear to make you rush.
5. Generic Signature	"Security Team" – no real person's name or phone number to call.

Risk Classification: PHISHING (High Risk)

Red Flags for Email 2

Red Flag	Why It's Suspicious
1. Generic Greeting	"Dear Valued Member" – Netflix knows your name and uses it in real emails.
2. Fake Sender Domain	The link netflix-account-update[.]top – Netflix uses netflix.com, not .top.
3. Suspicious Link	"Update Payment" looks real, but the domain is completely fake.
4. Urgency & Fear	"48 hours" – forces you to act without thinking.
5. Unsolicited Request	You didn't request a payment update; this came out of nowhere.

Risk Classification: PHISHING (High Risk)

Executive Summary

Phishing remains one of the most dangerous and common cyber threats because it exploits human psychology rather than technical vulnerabilities. Attackers use fear, urgency, and impersonation to trick users into clicking malicious links or sharing sensitive information.

This report analyzes two real-world phishing email samples:

- A fake bank account lock notification
- A fake Netflix subscription suspension alert

Both emails exhibit classic phishing indicators: generic greetings, suspicious sender domains, urgent language, and fake links. This document provides clear, non-technical prevention guidelines to help employees recognize and avoid these attacks. By implementing regular security awareness training, organizations can build a strong human firewall against phishing.

Risk Classification of Analyzed Emails

#	Email Subject	Sender Impersonation	Red Flags Found	Risk Level
1	Urgent: Account Lock	Fake Bank	Generic greeting, fake domain, urgency (24 hrs), no real signature	PHISHING (High)
2	Netflix Suspension	Fake Netflix	Generic greeting, fake .top domain, urgency (48 hrs), fake link	PHISHING (High)

How to Spot a Phishing Email – 5 Red Flags

1. Urgency or Threats – "Act now or your account will be closed!" Real companies give you time.
2. Generic Greetings – "Dear User" or "Dear Customer" instead of your real name. Legitimate emails use your name.
3. Suspicious Links – Hover over links (don't click!) to see the real URL. If it doesn't match the official domain, it's fake.
4. Unexpected Attachments – Do not open attachments from unknown senders. They may contain malware.
5. Spelling & Grammar Mistakes – Many phishing emails contain small typos or awkward phrasing.

Employee Prevention Guidelines

 DO's	 DON'Ts
Hover over links to preview the real URL before clicking.	Don't click on links in urgent emails without verifying.
Check the sender's email address carefully.	Don't trust emails with generic greetings like "Dear User".
Contact the company directly via phone to verify suspicious requests.	Don't share passwords, OTPs, or banking details via email.
Report suspicious emails to your IT/Security team.	Don't forward phishing emails to colleagues (send them to IT instead).

How the Attack Works

Phishing attacks don't break into your system, they trick you into opening the door. Here is exactly what happens, step by

step:

Step 1 — Attacker Creates a Fake Email

The attacker registers a domain that looks almost real, like secure-account-verify.com instead of your real bank's domain. They craft an email designed to look official, copying logos, fonts, and the tone of real company communications.

Step 2 — Victim Receives the Email

The email lands in your inbox using urgency — "24 hours", "account locked", "immediate action required" — to trigger a fear response. Fear makes people skip the checks they would normally do.

Step 3 — Victim Clicks the Fake Link

The link says "Verify Now" or "Update Payment" but the real destination URL is completely different. The fake website looks identical to the real one — same layout, same colors, same logo — but it is fully controlled by the attacker.

Step 4 — Credentials Are Stolen

When the victim types their username and password into the fake login page, those details are sent directly to the attacker's server, not to the real company. The attacker now has full access to the account.

Step 5 — Attacker Uses or Sells the Data

The stolen credentials are used immediately to transfer money or access sensitive data, or sold on the dark web. The victim often doesn't realize they've been compromised until damage has already been done.

Why This Works So Well:

- Exploits Trust — the email looks like it comes from a company you already know
- Exploits Fear — urgency stops people from thinking critically
- Exploits Habit — people are used to clicking links in emails without verifying them
- No technical skill needed — the attacker never hacks anything; the victim hands over access voluntarily

Key takeaway: The attack targets human psychology, not software. No antivirus can protect you if you willingly hand over your password. Awareness is the only defence

Appendix: Tools Used for Analysis

Figure 1: Raw text of the two phishing email samples analyzed in this report.

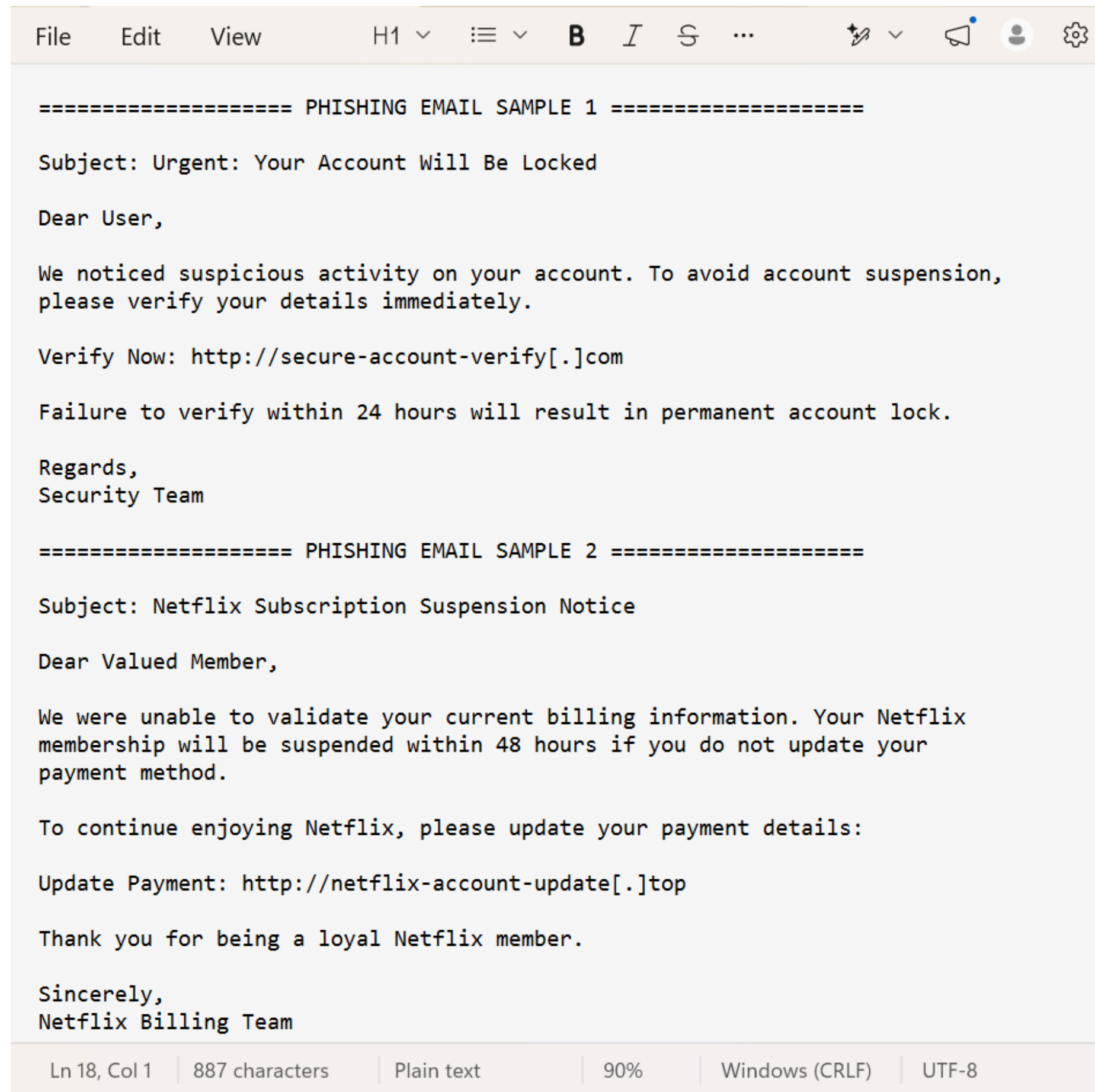
A screenshot of a text editor window with a light beige background. The editor displays two phishing email samples. The first sample is titled 'PHISHING EMAIL SAMPLE 1' and contains a subject line 'Urgent: Your Account Will Be Locked', a salutation 'Dear User,', a warning about account suspension, a verification link 'http://secure-account-verify[.]com', and a threat of permanent account lock. The second sample is titled 'PHISHING EMAIL SAMPLE 2' and contains a subject line 'Netflix Subscription Suspension Notice', a salutation 'Dear Valued Member,', a warning about membership suspension, a request to update payment details, a link 'http://netflix-account-update[.]top', and a closing from the 'Netflix Billing Team'. The editor's interface includes a menu bar (File, Edit, View), a toolbar with various icons, and a status bar at the bottom showing 'Ln 18, Col 1', '887 characters', 'Plain text', '90%', 'Windows (CRLF)', and 'UTF-8'.

Figure 2: Google Admin Toolbox

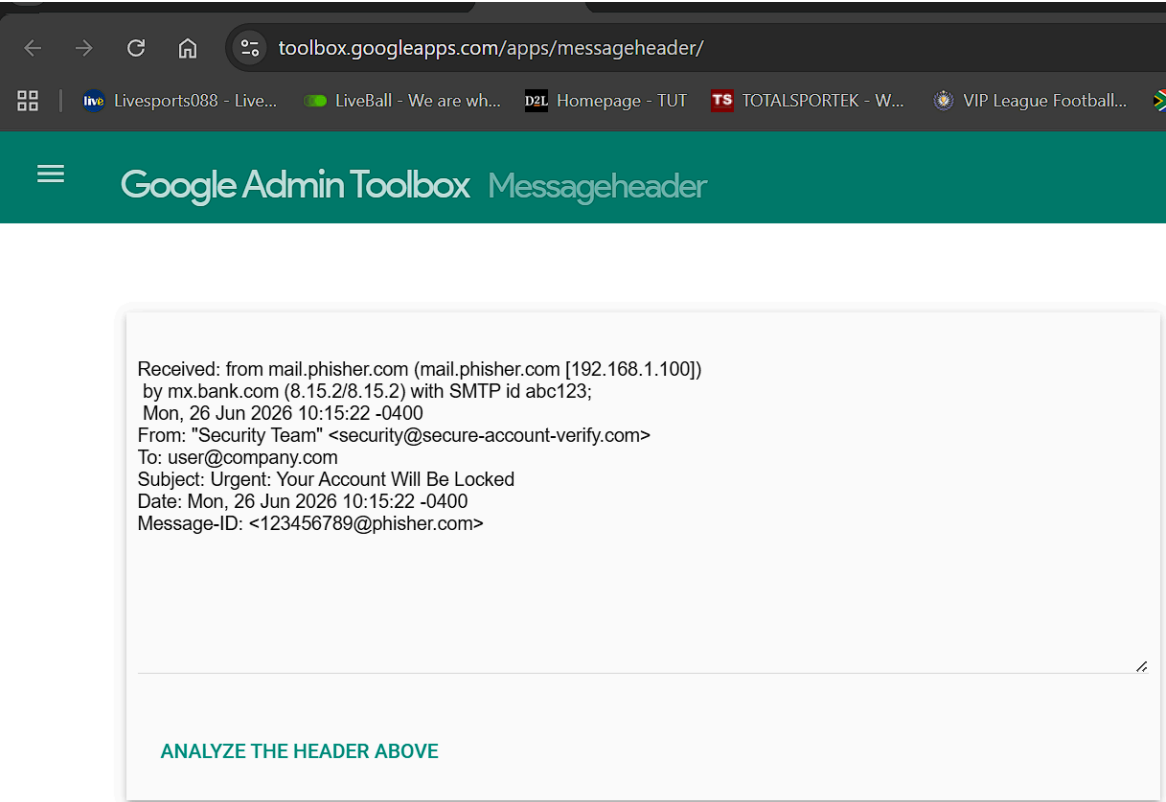
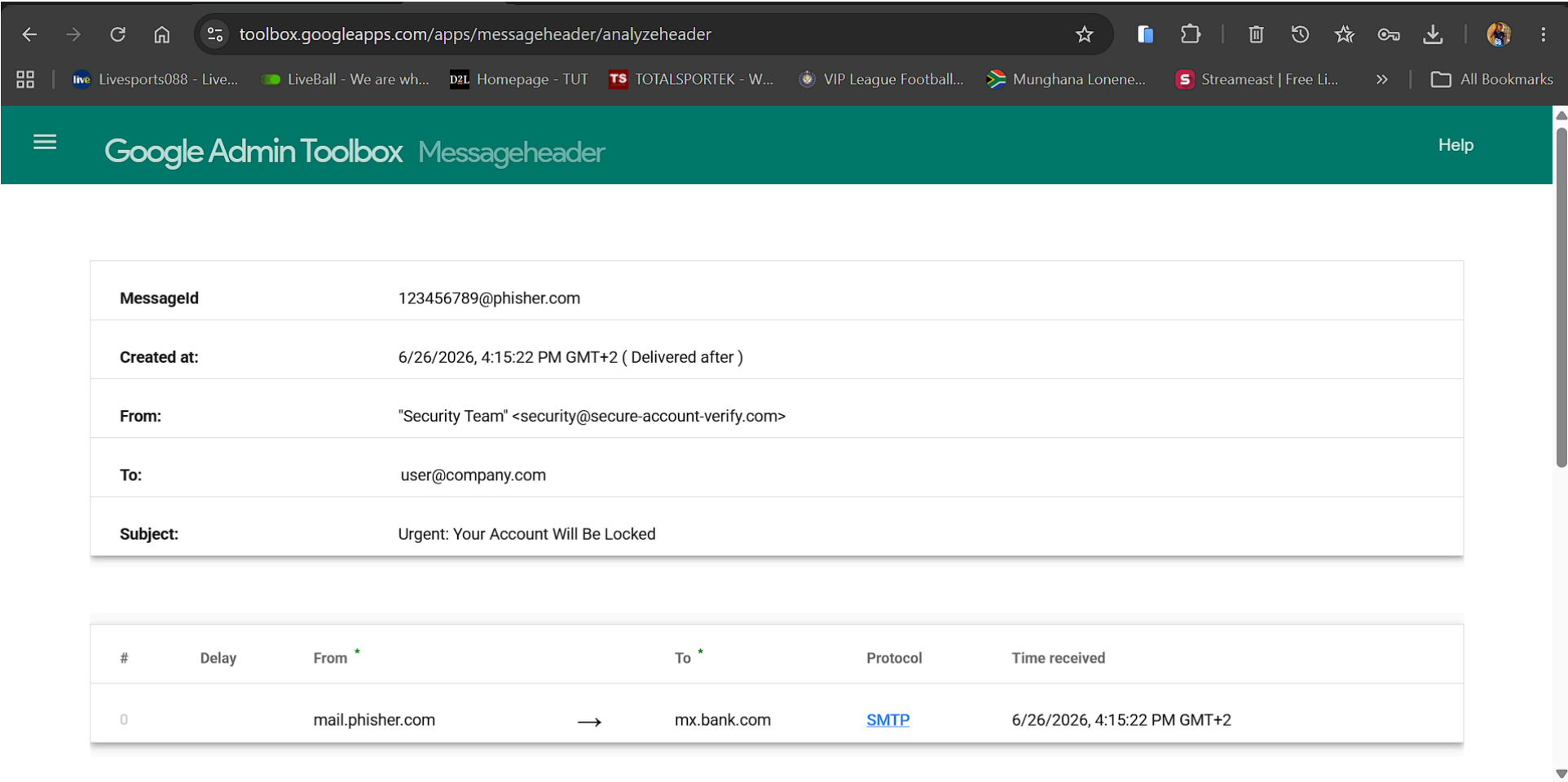


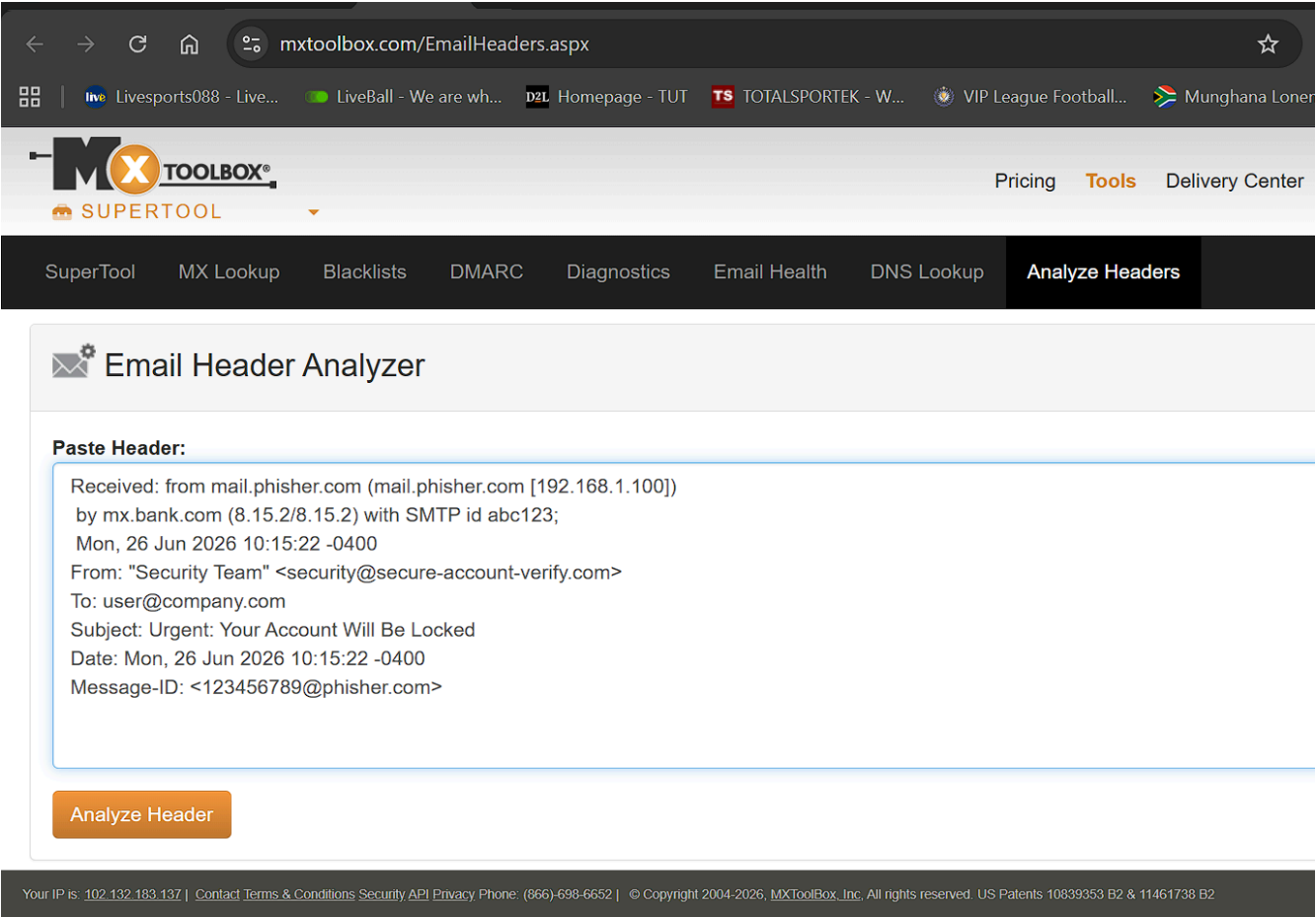
Figure 2.1

Example of what the output may look like



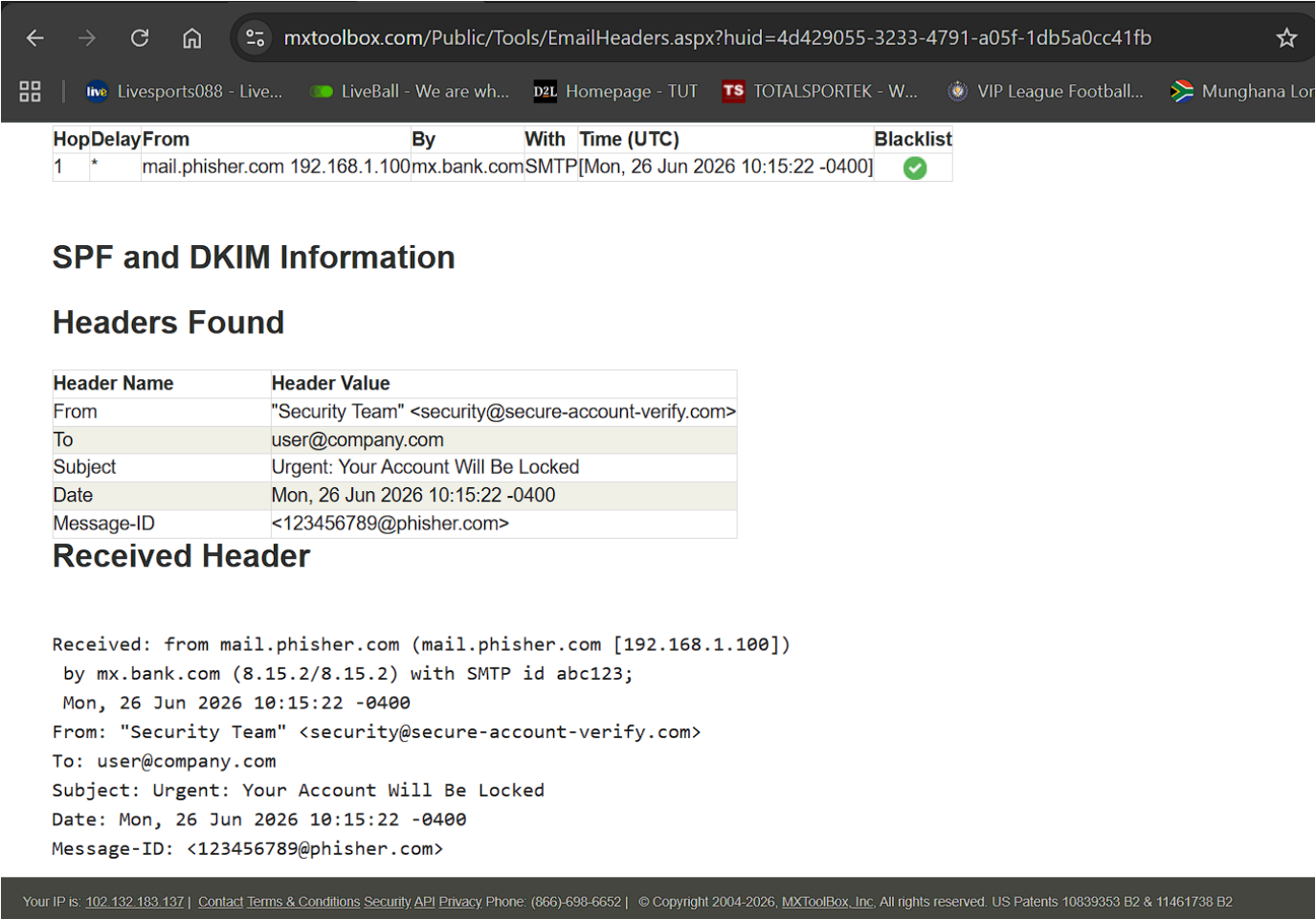
Google Admin Toolbox Messageheader – a tool used by security analysts to analyze email headers and identify spoofing or delivery issues.

Figure 3: MXToolbox Header Analyzer



MXToolbox Email Header Analyzer – another industry, standard tool for inspecting email headers and detecting phishing red flags.

Figure 3.1



Conclusion

Phishing attacks are effective because they target human behavior, not technology. The two emails analyzed in this report demonstrate classic attack patterns: fake domains, urgent language, and generic communication.

By educating employees to recognize these red flags, organizations can significantly reduce the risk of credential theft, data breaches, and financial loss. Awareness is the first and most important line of defense.

Remember: When in doubt, throw it out. If an email feels suspicious, it probably is.